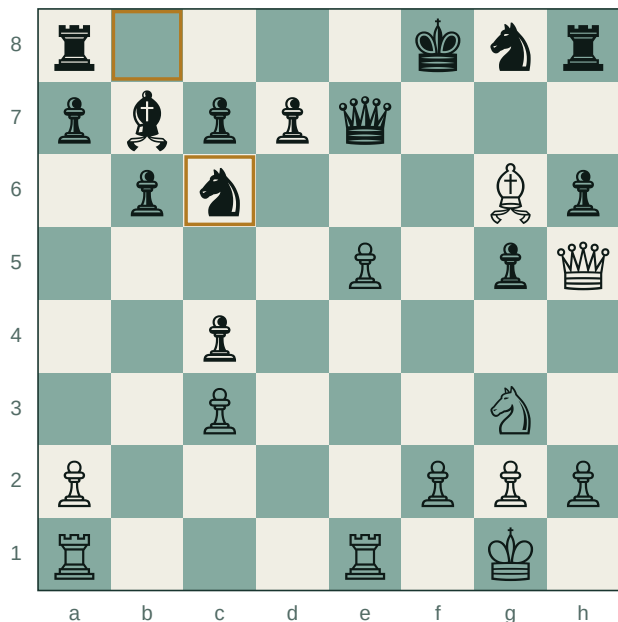


Exposed-king tactics: White, move 18

Exposed-king tactics

White to move



Previous move: 17...Nc6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18. Qf3+ Kg7 19. Nf5+ Kxg6 20. Nxe7+ Ncxe7 21. Qxb7

18.Qf3+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From f3 it attacks king on f8 and knight on c6. Recorded reply: **18...Kg7**.

19.Nf5+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. From f5 it attacks king on g7 and queen on e7. Recorded reply: **19...Kxg6**.

20.Nxe7+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From e7 it attacks king on g6, knight on g8 and knight on c6. Recorded reply: **20...Ncxe7**.

21.Qxb7 The queen captures the bishop on b7.

At the end, nominal material is White 25 / Black 23 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -4 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on f8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and bishop on b7. Check for tactical protection.